



Expressive and Receptive Language Issues with the Intellectually Disabled

People with an intellectual disability often have difficulties with:

- processing and learning new information,
- following directions,
- understanding and using written and spoken language (e.g. unable to follow conversation or verbally communicate their thoughts to others),
- comprehending detailed information
- completing tasks.

A person with an intellectual disability and communication deficits may also **struggle with social skills and understanding the non-verbal communication of others**, such as understanding facial expression, gestures or social etiquette. In people who do not speak at all, or have limited verbal abilities, they can be helped by developing alternative communication methods, such as using assistive technology such as picture boards.

Helping People with Speech Issues

As with most therapeutic interventions, the first step generally involves obtaining a complete background of the person's social, education and medical history, as well as their current level of functioning in regard to speech and communication.

Speech therapy and receptive language: Receptive language refers to the person's ability to take in and understand information. We can help a person with receptive language challenges by working on areas such as:

- building eye contact,
- using minimal instructions and basic language,
- expanding the individual's vocabulary,
- focusing on specific words to learn,
- incorporating visual cues such as pictures, gestures or body language to enhance understanding.

Support for issues involving receptive language often involves asking the person to state what has been said to them and helping the person recognize an instruction or concept and act on the information.

Speech therapy and expressive language: Expressive language involves the ability to express ideas, choices, feelings and needs. Hardships in this area can be improved by:

- constant engagement in conversation, such as asking them to describe their ideas or actions,
- modeling the mechanism of generating speech sounds and words to the person,
- using books to tell stories and encouraging letter writing,
- broaden the person's vocabulary, which is often done by exposing them to social experiences, reading or consuming other media, or engaging in exercises where they have to name objects or actions in everyday activities.

Speech therapy and social language: Social or practical communication skills are required to properly adopt language within a social context. These skills are often crucial for a person to engage in their community and with their peers, and involve:

- How we use language in various ways (e.g. making requests of other people, social greetings);
- Adapting how we use language to the social situation (e.g. we often speak differently to our peers than we do to a stranger or a person older than us);
- Learning social etiquette and standards (e.g. understanding social cues, importance of taking turns).

We can enhance practical language skills by applying aids (e.g. the use of photos that help us say what we want to say) and modeling appropriate conduct in specific social contexts (e.g. greetings, manners), using role playing and teaching the individual to better read and understand facial expressions. It is also critical for the person to be engaged in a variety of social interactions in everyday life.

Speech therapy and persons who do not use speech: When a person is showing signs of being unable to produce sounds or speak, it becomes necessary to find alternative ways of communication. This often includes the use of gestures and body language, visual aids and objects (e.g. picture boards or cards), or learning sign language. Therapy usually has an initial focus of developing the person's skills to be able to communicate practical messages, such as how to show that they are hungry and represent emotions (e.g. using picture cards to display if they are tired or happy). It may take some time to identify what is most comfortable for the person to use in terms of alternative communication approaches. As things progress and the person's communication skills increase, we will work to enhance the person's ability to manage complex tasks and instructions that include more actions.

Speech Therapy Games for Adults

Speech therapy activities are a fun way for people of all ages to develop the skills they need to communicate better and gain confidence.

1. **Heads Up! Smartphone Game:** Heads Up! is a smartphone app game that combines trivia and charades. (download it from the Apple App Store or from Google Play.) The

player who will be guessing the word or phrase holds the smartphone on their forehead, revealing the word or phrase to others, who act out clues. Helps with: Learning to speak in turn.

2. **Opposites Attract:** In this game, one player makes a list of words that have a clear opposite, such as "yes," "down," "happy," etc. The player reads each word aloud and the other player states the opposite. Helps with: Word finding, speaking in turn.
3. **Group Chat:** Set a topic, such as a movie or current event, and create a safe space for players to discuss. This is a great way to practice more natural communication. Helps with: Speaking in turn, sentence fluency.
4. **Name Game:** This activity involves naming items within a certain category. The best way to play is with cards that have written directions on them, such as "Name five fruits." In turn, each player picks a card and responds to the directions. Helps with: Word finding.
5. **Journaling:** Because reading and language development are interconnected, writing in a journal can help people improve language production and comprehension. Provide a list of writing prompts that the player can choose from. Have them write without stopping for 5 or 10 minutes. Helps with: Word finding, sentence fluency.
6. **Name Ten:** Similar to the name game, the player is given a category and is asked to name ten things that fit within that category. For example, you can ask the player to name ten colors, fruits, animals, or sports. Helps with: Word finding.
7. **Sound-Focused Game:** Players choose a sound they want to target, such as an "S" or "T" sound. Then they take turns saying sentences aloud using as many words as possible that include that sound. For example, if players are targeting an "S" sound, one player might say, "My sister Sally sat sideways in the seat." Helps with: Pronunciation, word finding.

Activities to work on speech, language and communication goals.

- **Newspapers.** A newspaper—target literacy, answering and asking questions about current events, searching for a movie time and location, and social skills or abstract language in the comics section.
- **Magazines.** Age-appropriate and interesting magazines contain a variety of articles, pictures, advertisements and more. Also, the magazines your clients choose may give you insights into their interests and motivations.
- **Grocery circulars.** Use free circulars to learn money management, categories (such as food groups) and new food vocabulary.

- **Brochures/catalogs.** Brochures and catalogs motivate and engage clients depending on their interests. If your client likes electronics, bring an electronics catalog, for example. Discuss prices, various types of equipment and what they like versus dislike. The same approach works for clothing, gardening or home décor catalogs.
- **Subway/bus maps.** Work on travel training, literacy and map reading with these resources. Language concepts include problem-solving, sequencing and answering "wh" (who, what, where, when and why) questions.
- **Menus.** What's more functional than being able to read a menu and make a choice?
- **Employment applications.** Stop into any fast-food establishment, restaurant, movie theater or retail store and ask for an application. Filling out an application facilitates improved literacy, answering "wh" questions, recalling information, expanding vocabulary, and sequencing by writing the order of educational or work history.
- **Dominoes.** A set of dominoes offers an inexpensive, portable, age-appropriate and fun developmental activity for adults. Practice matching, taking turns, solving problems and following directions.
- **Playing cards.** Ideas for card games include Uno, Go Fish and War. Examples of targeted goals include matching, solving problems, taking turns and prediction.
- **Board games/bingo.** How about a game of Sorry or Connect Four? These games teach taking turns, learning colors, following directions and solving problems.